

TALKING TO TEENS

Build up rapport in six stages...

- 1 Start with generic experiences—the last holiday, what they like or don't like
- 2 Discuss specific experiences—arguments, exam tension, etc
- 3 Thrash out the context in which the above occur—home, school and neighbourhood
- 4 Talk about the institutions within these contexts, say, friendship and marriage
- 5 Experiences and feelings within these institutions—love, attraction and romance
- 6 Hammer out issues like sexuality, depression, or even suicidal ideas

Source: The Window Method, Dr S. Sheshadri, NIMHANS

changes. (see chart)

What have we done to our children? In a wake-up call, the Lok Sabha last month made a plea to review and change the school examination system drastically. But as young blood spills, doctors rue the lack of a national suicide intervention programme. Sporadic prevention strategies are being put in place across the country: NIMHANS regularly holds suicide prevention workshops; CMC, Vellore, is seeking to ban the sale of lethal pesticides; AIIMS is working on mental health in Delhi schools; the Central Board of Secondary Education has included training in life skills to help children cope with stress. Though teenagers are frightened and hurt by the deaths of their friends, there's not much as yet for parents whose shock and fear are the greatest. "When something like this happens, I think a lot about my children," says Seema Shukla, a mother who runs her graphic design studio in Delhi. "I hope I raised them right.

whole cluster of changes in their behaviour and mood and sleep and eating patterns and energy levels." Medics tell parents to look for dramatic changes in behaviour or appearance, in weight and in school performance. Any talk about wanting to die or committing suicide should make a parent go on red alert.

Yet many families are loath to discuss the topic with their children. "There is this notion about depression, and certainly about suicide, that if you ask or mention the subject, you're going to make it happen," says Sheshadri. Quite the contrary; talking with a son or daughter about dark feelings will help assuage the sense of hopelessness the child may have. What should you do if you think your teenager is suicidal? Stay calm, cool and collected, advise doctors. Enlist the help of a professional—psychologist, psychiatrist, school counsellor or social worker. Pediatricians and doctors can also be of assistance.

82%

teens wish to talk about themselves, but 76% parents discuss only career issues

ner," says a relative.

School is the other controlling factor which determines the ups and downs of teen lives. On April 4, a 12-year-old student in Bhayandar, Mumbai, tried to kill herself by jumping on the railway track from a flyover. Reason? She had been caught copying red-handed by a teacher the previous day. Her parents were summoned to the school and she was not allowed to take the English examination. The next day, she was barred from sitting for other exams as well, despite profuse pleading and apologies. She returned home and later in the afternoon tried to scale the wall to end her life. Worse, the person who rescued the distraught girl was rebuffed by the school for taking her over to them. New research by AIIMS, probing the teen mind, throws up "school refusal" as a classic symptom of adolescent depression. The symptoms range from aggression to crying spells, lethargy and even personality



HEMANT CHAWLA

These are the dangerous years. You don't always know what's going on inside their heads."

Difficult. Distant. Moody. Teens are all that and more. Most of the time such behaviour simply means normal teen angst. But the challenge for parents is to make out the difference against despair. Luckily, there are recognisable warning signs that many experts agree on. "There's not one symptom that's going to leap out to a parent," says Mehta. "It's rather a

Despite the extent of knowledge today, signs of deep trouble too often go unheeded. "In nearly every case of suicide I have reviewed, clues to the adolescent's plans were overlooked or downplayed," says Gururaj. "Not intentionally but unknowingly." Not all suicides can be prevented, but parents who keep an eye on their teenagers and work hard at communicating with them are the ones most likely to save their children's lives.

with Subhash Mishra